

Giant Pacific octopus

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OCEAN



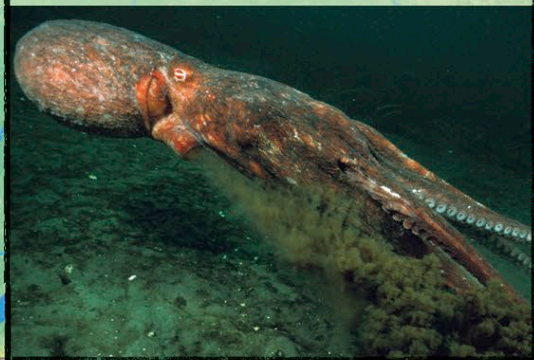
Weighing as much as two grown men, the giant Pacific octopus is the largest of all octopus species, and one of the biggest ocean predators without a backbone. It is an agile, intelligent hunter, capable of catching prey as big as sharks.

Food chain trouble

The Sea of Okhotsk is rich in the food the giant octopus eats, such as fish, shellfish, and crabs. But as climate change causes ocean waters to warm up, the food sources on which the octopus depends are put at risk.

Moves and tricks

Giant Pacific octopuses crawl or glide across the seabed, but for a quick getaway they push water from inside their body out through a funnel, to create jet propulsion. They do not have many predators, but if threatened they squirt out ink to confuse their attacker, as shown below.



In deeper waters

In summer, giant octopuses migrate into deeper, offshore waters to mate, sometimes reaching down to 4,900 ft (1,500 m). In fall, they return to the coast, where females lay their eggs.

Clever fishing

Giant octopuses in Japanese waters have been fitted with radio transmitters to follow their movements. Many have been found to follow commercial fishing nets to steal a meal.

KEY

 Giant Pacific octopus range